Paul's Old Testament Story

Because Isaac, the child of promise, could never share an inheritance with Ishmael, the child of the flesh, the believer — born by the same kind of promise — must cast out every attempt to mix law-keeping with grace and stand in the freedom to which Christ has called him.

Source: Dr. C. Norman Sellers, ThD · SellersBibleInstitute.com · used by permission

Where this study fits

Galatians · sixteen studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 The Ground of Liberty	**02** 1:6–10 The One True Gospel	**03** 1:11–17 Paul's Independent Revelation	**04** 1:18–2:10 Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches
05 2:11–21 Peter Goes Back to School	**06** 3:1–5 Under a Spell	**07** 3:6–14 Blessing or a Curse	**08** 3:15–29 The Superiority of the Promise to the Law
09 4:1–11 When I Became a Man	**10** 4:12–20 A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove	**11** 4:21–31 Paul's Old Testament Story	**12** 5:1–12 Taking a Stand in Liberty
13 5:13–26 Walk in the Spirit	**14** 6:1–5 Brothers and Burdens	**15** 6:6–10 Sowing and Reaping	**16** 6:11–18 Teaching the Truth

The key is the number two

Galatians 4:21–31 · Introduction

	Bondage — the left column	Freedom — the right column
Two sons	Ishmael	Isaac
Two women	Hagar, the bondwoman (παιδίσκη)	Sarah, the freewoman (ἐλευθέρα)
Two spheres	Flesh	Spirit — promise
Two covenants	Law	Promise
Two places	Arabia	Jerusalem
Two mountains	Sinai	Zion
Two Jerusalems	The Jerusalem that now is	The Jerusalem above (ἄνω)

Signed up without reading the fine print

Galatians 4:21 · Outline I — The argument

What they wanted

- “You who desire to be under the law”
- Law-keeping as their way to please God

What they had not heard

- “Do you not hear the law?”
- What the law demands — and what it produces
- Paul's answer comes from the law itself: Genesis

They signed up for the law without reading what was in it.

Two sons, two births

Galatians 4:22–23 · Outline II.A–B

Ishmael — “according to the flesh”

- Son of Hagar, the bondwoman
- Sarah's plan, by human means
- Apart from God's revealed will
- No miracle

Isaac — “through promise”
δι' ἐπαγγελίας through promise

- Son of Sarah, the freewoman
- When God said, as God said
- Against all natural possibility
- Abraham called at 75; God waited 25 years

Make it as hard as it can be — so that when it happens, everyone knows God did it.

History made into an allegory

Galatians 4:24–27 · Outline II.C — Two symbols

v.24a	Historical events, used as an allegory — not fiction	**ἀλληγορούμενα** Pres. Pass. Ptc. — made into
v.24b	Mount Sinai “gives birth to bondage” — Hagar	**γεννῶσα · δουλείαν** continually bearing · slavery
v.25	Hagar “corresponds to Jerusalem which now is”	**συστοιχεῖ** stands in the same rank
v.26	“The Jerusalem above is free, which is the mother of us all”	**ἄνω** above — heavenly
v.27	“Rejoice, O barren” — Isaiah 54:1	**στεῖρα** barren — yet more fruitful

Children of promise: four applications

Galatians 4:28–31 · Outline III — The application

A Children of promise

v.28
“Now we, brethren, as Isaac was, are children of promise”

B Candidates for persecution

ἐδίωκεν · v.29
The child of the flesh kept persecuting the child of the Spirit

C No compromise

Ἔκβαλε · v.30
“Cast out the bondwoman and her son” — they shall not be heirs together

D Called to liberty

v.31
“We are not children of the bondwoman but of the free”

Law: work six days, then rest — working for the blessing. Grace: rest first, then work — working from the blessing.

Discuss and apply

Galatians 4:21–31 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Paul says the Jerusalem above “is the mother of us all.” What does it mean practically to live as a citizen of that city?

2. What would it look like concretely to “cast out” a legalistic rule you've let sit alongside your faith in Christ?

Apply

Know Which Column You're In
Identify one requirement you've added, and set it back outside your standing with God — not a condition of it.

Work From the Blessing, Not For It
Do one act of service this week from rest and gratitude rather than obligation to earn favor.

In one line: Two sons, two covenants — and only one column a believer can stand in.